TEN

Potential Solutions to the Kashmir Conflict

A permanent peaceful resolution to Kashmir's conflict will require solemn diplomatic agreements between India and Pakistan that have the full support of Kashmir's most popular leaders. For ten years after the Kashmir problem was first brought to the UN Security Council by India, heroic efforts were made by the UNCIP's global diplomats to resolve the conflict through a comprehensive or limited plebiscite supervised by UN monitors, or by the division of Jammu and Kashmir into its dominant ethno-religious units—Hindu Jammu and Buddhist Ladakh going to India, and the Muslim-majority Kashmir Valley to Pakistan.

India's repeated adamant refusal to accept any of those Security Council proposed resolutions, however, has by now removed them from the realm of realistic options. The Simla Accord of 1972, which committed both India and Pakistan to settling "their differences by peaceful means through bilateral negotiations," explicitly ruled out any "unilateral altering" of the situation, or multinational resolutions of the conflict, keeping the United States out of any open mediatory role in creating a final resolution for Kashmir. In 2004, both Vajpayee and Musharraf appeared ready, nonetheless, to agree on a "last try" to resolve this toughest of current global conflicts by accepting the Line of Control as the Indo-Pakistani international border. Musharraf then immediately reneged, however, insisting that he could never agree to thus seeking to turn the "cause" of their conflict over Kashmir into its resolution. His Punjabi military colleagues had apparently refused to consider Vajpayee's final solution in any way acceptable.